

Spencer Lighthill's Memories

Seeing some interesting stories of early times, in your paper which I enjoy reading, impels me to write a short sketch of some fact connected with early times.

I was born in Pennsylvania, in Beaver County, May 30 1836 and I am proud as we "boys" march along with the 'rife and drums'; and the children go by with the garlands of flowers, that I have reached another milestone on the westward slope of life.

When I was two years old my parents moved to Richland County, Ohio where they lived until I was fifteen, then moved to Paulding County, Ohio, and I have resided here ever since.

When I was a boy, seven years old, I worked five days for a neighbor, at ten cents a day, and received a half-dollar for my work,. This half-dollar has ever been in my possession, since the evening it was given me, as my hire, and it has been prized by me for two reasons: one, it was the first money I ever earned, and the other it was coined the same year my parents were married.

"On reaching Paulding County, my parents moved on a farm in Section twenty-four of Brown township, and I resided wit until I married. Then I moved on a farm in Section twenty-three of same township, and have resided here ever since. Wife and I have been married fifty-seven years, and we have reasonably good health, although the years are tolling some on us now, yet I am able to walk to Oakwood and back, a distance of five miles.

Game was very plentiful when we came to Paulding County, and many is the time that I have tracked the wild beast to his lair, and secured his pelt; because it was one of the means of getting money at that time. In fact money was so scarce that one year I paid my taxes with "raccoon skins."

I came to the county before the time of roads, and have helped to cut out a good may of them, especially some of the first ones. There were no ditches at the time of which I write. And sometimes the roads became impassible unless they were corduroyed.

My family traces its ancestry to two Vice Presidents viz: R. N. Johnson and T.A.Hendricks and one President James Buchanan. Both my grandfathers fought under Washington, my father fought under Harrison of Tippecanoe fame. I have two grandsons that served in the regular army of the U.S.A. and I was in company F, 38th, and company I, 100th O.V.I. during the great struggle from '61 to '65.

While helping to cut the road, that afterwards became first street of Oakwood, we found a skeleton. It was between two logs, there was a hole in it which resembled a bullet hole. It was generally believed at that time that the person had been murdered.

Over such highways as there were in the "fifties" it was hard work to get our milling done. Sometimes we carried our grist to mill, sometimes it was carried on horseback and at other times it was boated to mill. The latter had plenty of hard work connected with it, we could take more at a

time, so the neighbors would go together and fill the old "Pirogue" and float down the river to mill. To go down was easy enough, but coming against the current was different.

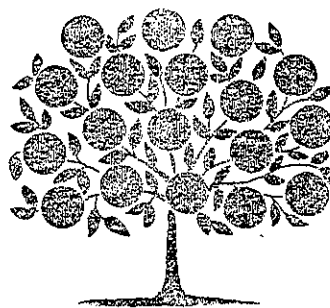
In early times there were no churches and the schoolhouses were used as a place of worship. At one time the Rev. Silas Martin came to the schoolhouse to preach. He brought his rifle with him which he stood in the corner. At the close of the services, he shouldered his rifle and proceeded to look for game. As that was the way a greater part of his salary was collected. He talked life everlasting to his congregation, but his rifle spoke death to the wild life of the forest.

I am an old man now and my name has never been written as great or near great. But I did one thing of which I am proud. When the little village of Oakwood was asking for a post office, the suggestion was sent to the government to call it "Clemons ville" and was rejected. As the neighbors in the little community had gathered about the store and were discussing a new name, my eyes rested on a massive white oak and I suggested the name of Oakwood, which name was accepted by the government and that is how the village received its name.

My wife and I have lived thirty-six years in the house which we are now occupying and have never had a death in same, and but very little sickness. But our eyes are on the low-hung sun and we are expecting to hear the call "come home" at any time, for "I have prepared a place for you."

Source: **Shelby Noffsinger** gave this type written article to the society. Thank you Shelby for this first hand account of Paulding County.

Editor's Note: Spencer Lighthill married Mary Hamilton 28 Jul 1860 in Paulding County. Spencer (1836-1927) and Mary (1835-1922) are buried at the Prairie Chapel Cemetery in Paulding County with other family members.



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